



Department of
Criminal Justice

Part of the UPPP Series

Utah Prison Population Projections: 2026 Annual Update



September 2026

justice.utah.gov

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Report Highlights



~An analysis of UDC prison data based on the average daily population between 2010:Q1 through 2026:Q2~

6,665

The average daily prison population reached 6,665 inmates in 2025 Q4 - up 308 inmates from 2024 Q4.



Five-year projections indicate annual prison population growth ranging from 1.9% to 2.5%.



While admissions have declined from their post-COVID peak they continued to exceed releases in 2025.



A continued shift toward more serious offenses is expected to place continued pressure on the prison population.



Recent legislations is under review to better understand its potential impact on future prison population trends.



Regular updates allow projections to be refined as new data become available and adjusted to reflect changing trends.

INTRODUCTION



In collaboration with the Utah Department of Corrections, the Utah Department of Criminal Justice has been developing five-year projections of Utah's prison population to examine recent population trends and key drivers of growth.

This second annual report provides updated five-year projections of Utah's prison population, examining current population pressures and how projected growth is expected to align with available capacity.

To capture a range of potential outcomes and reduce planning uncertainty, the report presents scenario-based projections alongside analysis of key trends and growth factors to inform ongoing planning and decision-making.

This report analyzes 3 areas related to prison population growth:

1

Historical Trends

Examines Utah's prison population over time and recent trends.

2

Prison Drivers

Reviews important drivers behind current population growth.

3

Projections

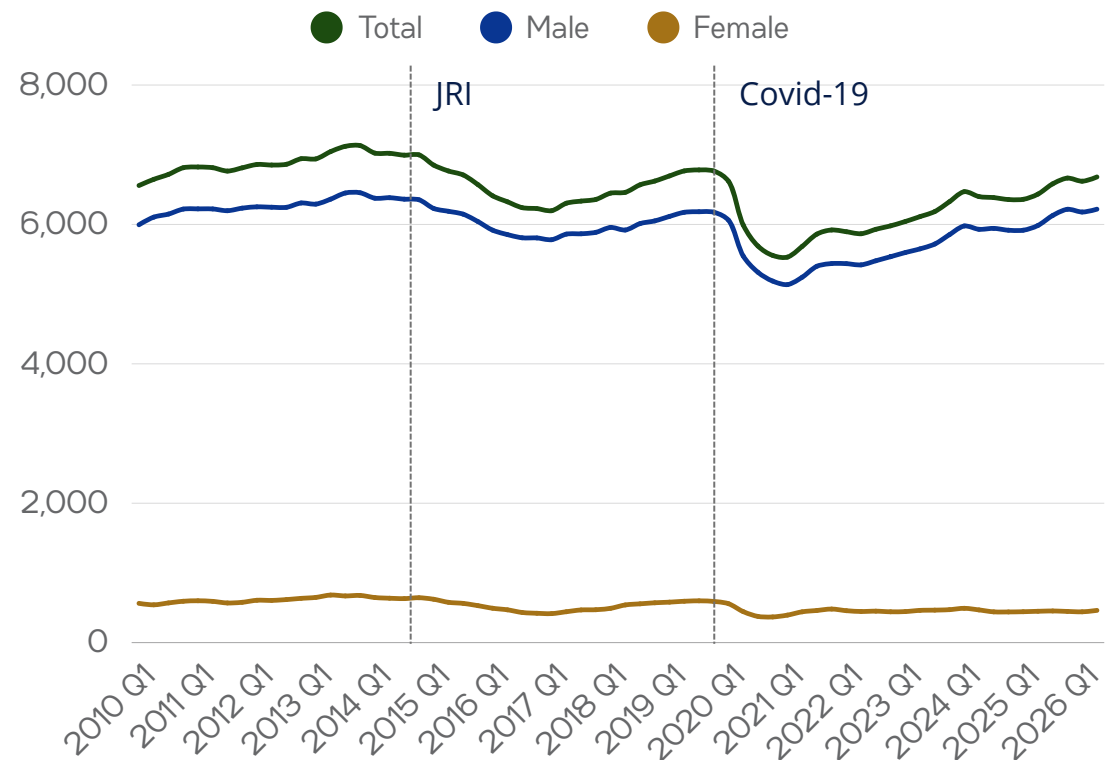
Presents five-year projections and makes recommendations on findings.

HISTORICAL TRENDS

While policy shifts under the Justice Reinvestment Initiative (JRI) in 2016 and operational changes during the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020 temporarily lowered inmate counts, similar to other states, **Utah's prison population has experienced consistent upward pressure over the past 15 years.**

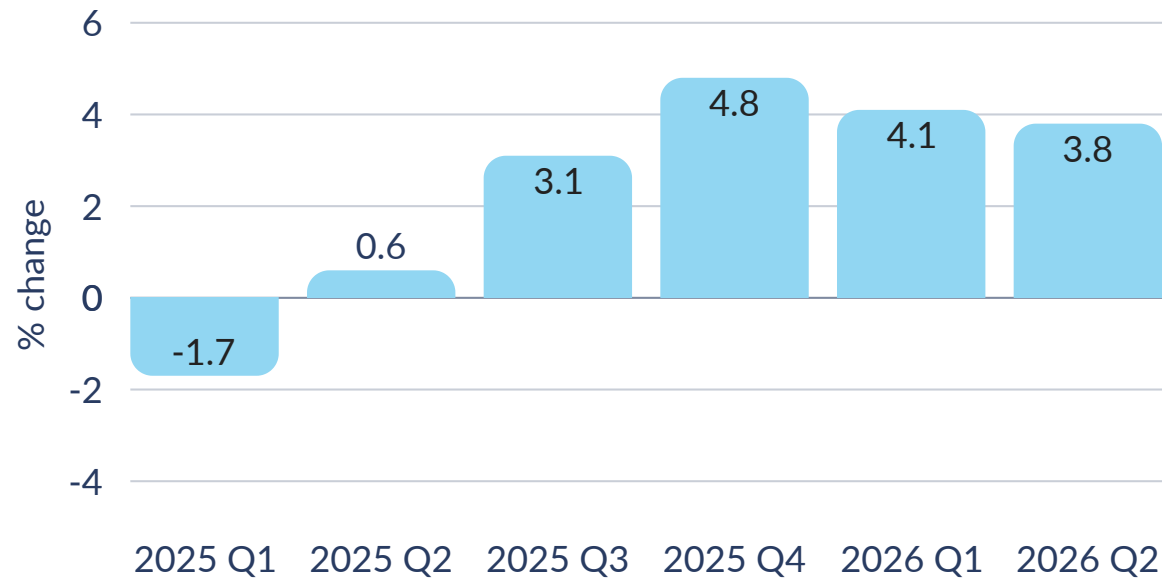
By the end of 2025, the average daily population reached 6,665 inmates (6,217 males and 448 females). Population levels varied throughout the year, with slower growth early in 2025 followed by stronger growth in the middle and latter parts of the year. **By 2026 Q2, the population had reached 6,681, starting to approach pre-COVID levels.**

Figure 1: Utah's Prison Population: 2010 Q1- 2026 Q2



Annual Growth

Figure 2: Quarterly Year-to-Year Change in Inmates - Total : 2024 Q1 - 2026 Q2



Preliminary Key-Takeaways: Historical Trends

308

Added Inmates

UDC's prison population increased by an average of 308 inmates in 2025.



Fluctuations

Quarterly fluctuations with more significant growth in mid to late 2025.



Males

Population growth in 2025/26 was driven by males.

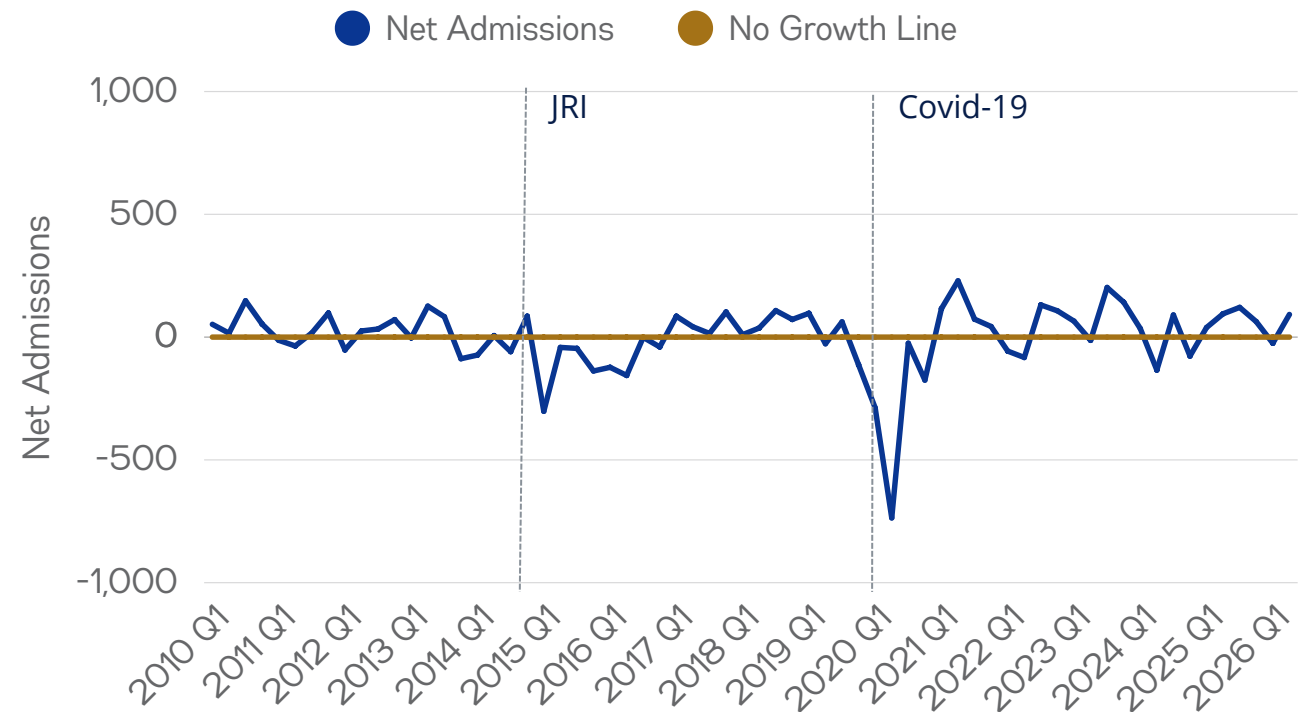
PRISON DRIVERS

Admissions and releases determine the flow of people into and out of prison. In 2025, net admissions (admissions minus releases) had a median value of 29 per quarter.

Figure 3 illustrates this relationship over time. When the blue line is above zero, admissions exceeded releases and the population increased; when the line is at zero, admissions and releases were balanced; and when the line falls below zero, releases exceeded admissions and the population declined.

For information on internal ways UDC have identified to control prison population pressures please visit: [this link](#).

Figure 3: Net Admissions (Admissions - Releases): 2010:Q1-2026:Q2



Prison Drivers Cont.

Figure 4: Prison Admissions: 2010:Q1-2026:Q2

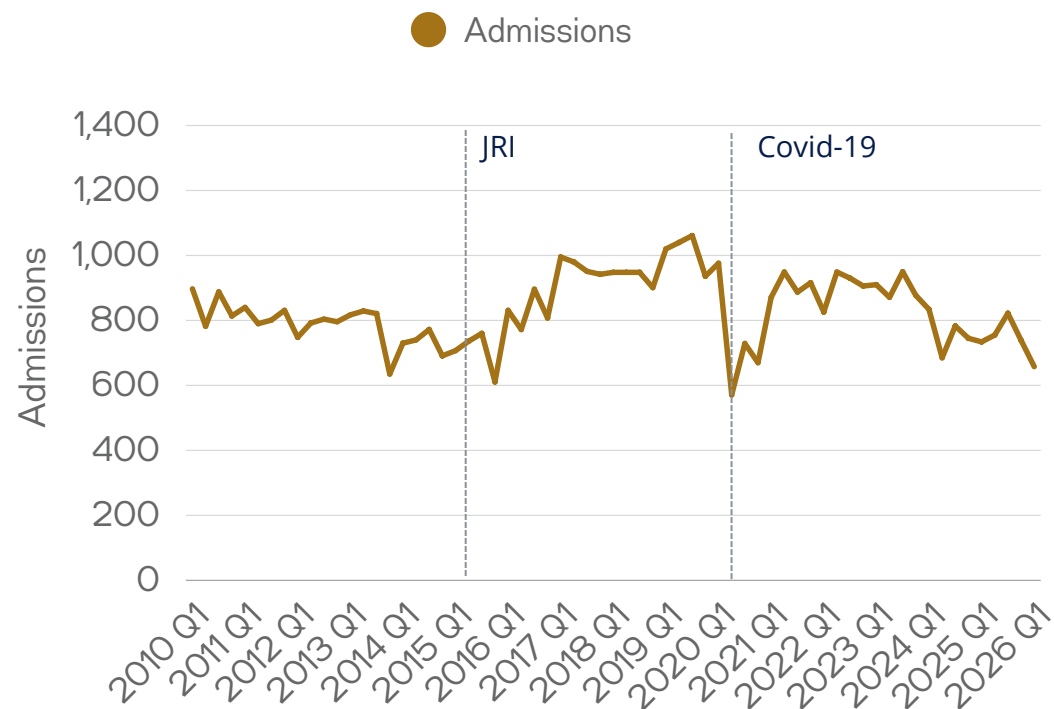
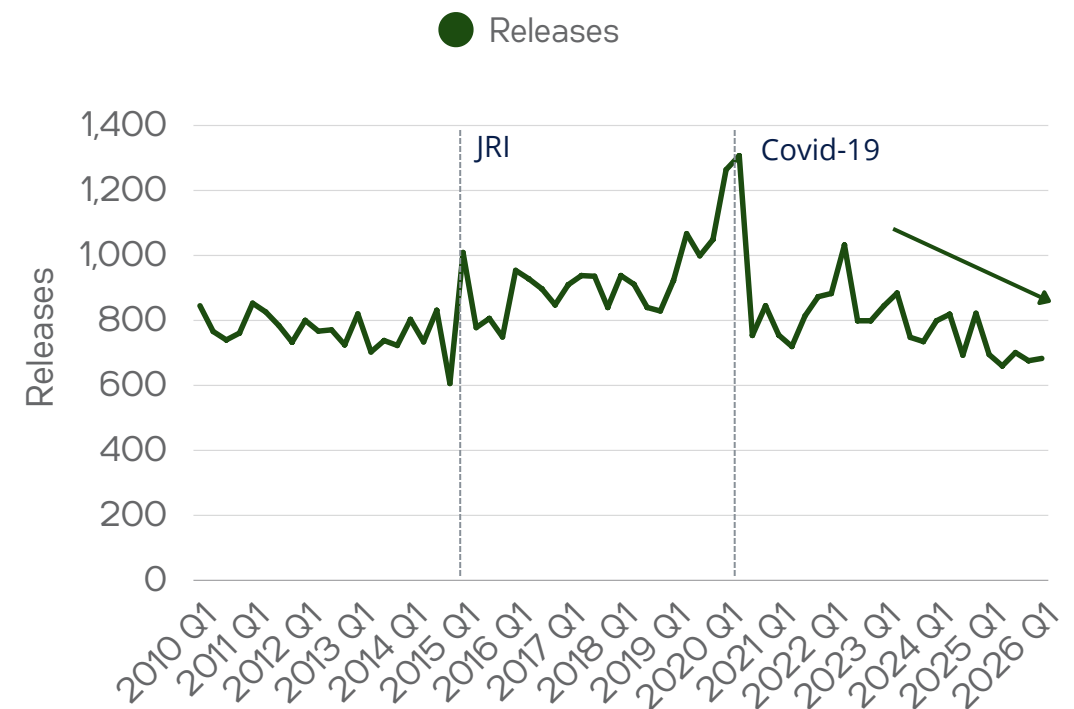
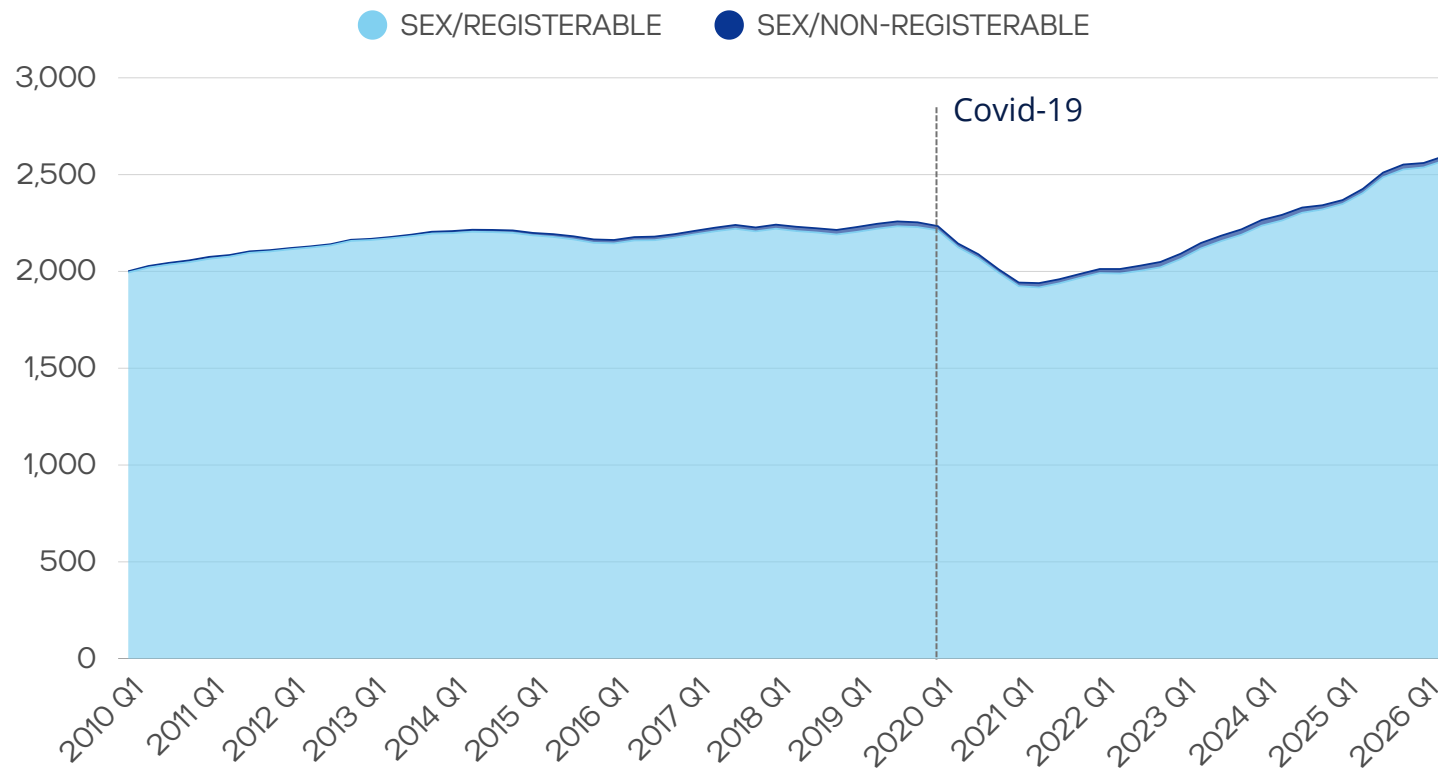


Figure 5: Prison Releases: 2010:Q1-2026:Q2



Prison Drivers Cont.

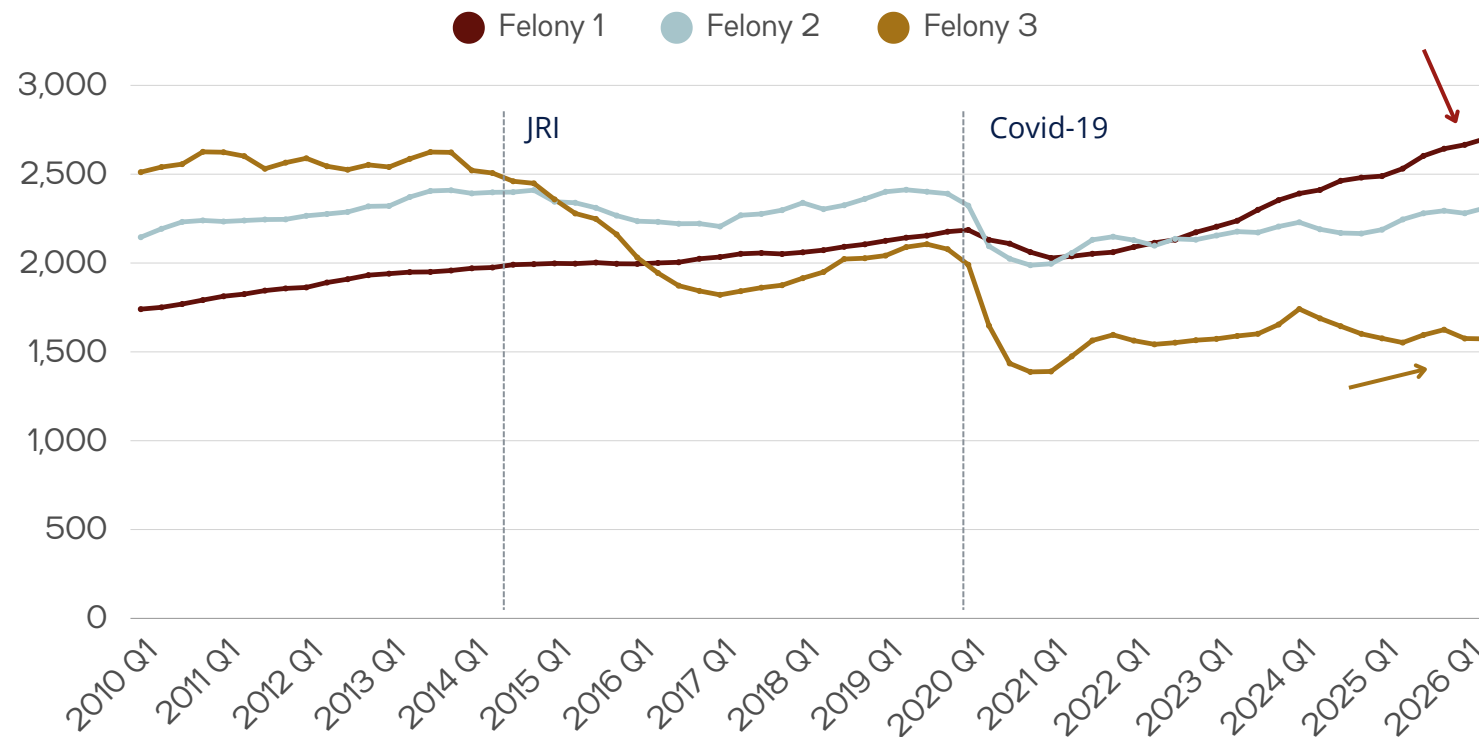
Figure 6: Utah Prison Population (sex offenses): 2010:Q1-2026:Q2



Individuals convicted of sex offenses continues to make up nearly **40% of the prison population** and continued to grow in 2025 and part of 2026.

Prison Drivers Cont.

Figure 7: Utah Prison Population by Offense Degree: 2010:Q1-2026:Q2*

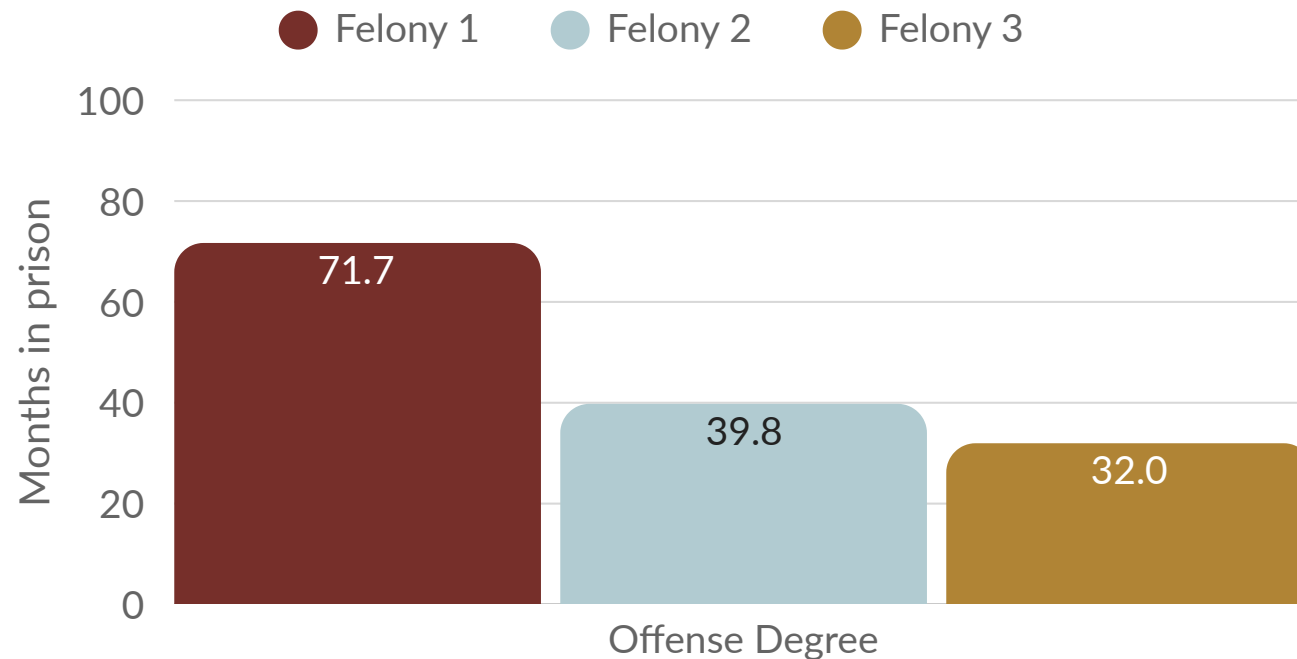


*Includes Felony 1–3 offenses and excludes smaller degree categories (e.g., Misd. A).

Utah's prison population is continued to **shift toward higher offense degrees**, particularly Felony 1.

Length of Stay by Degree

Figure 8: Prison Length of Stay by Degree in Months - Registerable Sex Offenses - Release Year 2025



Source: UDC internal calculations made available to DOCJ.

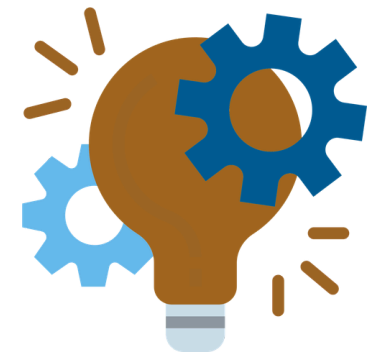
Among sex-related offenses, the largest crime category, **Felony 1 offenses** have an average length of stay **~40 months longer** than Felony 3 offenses.

PRISON PROJECTIONS



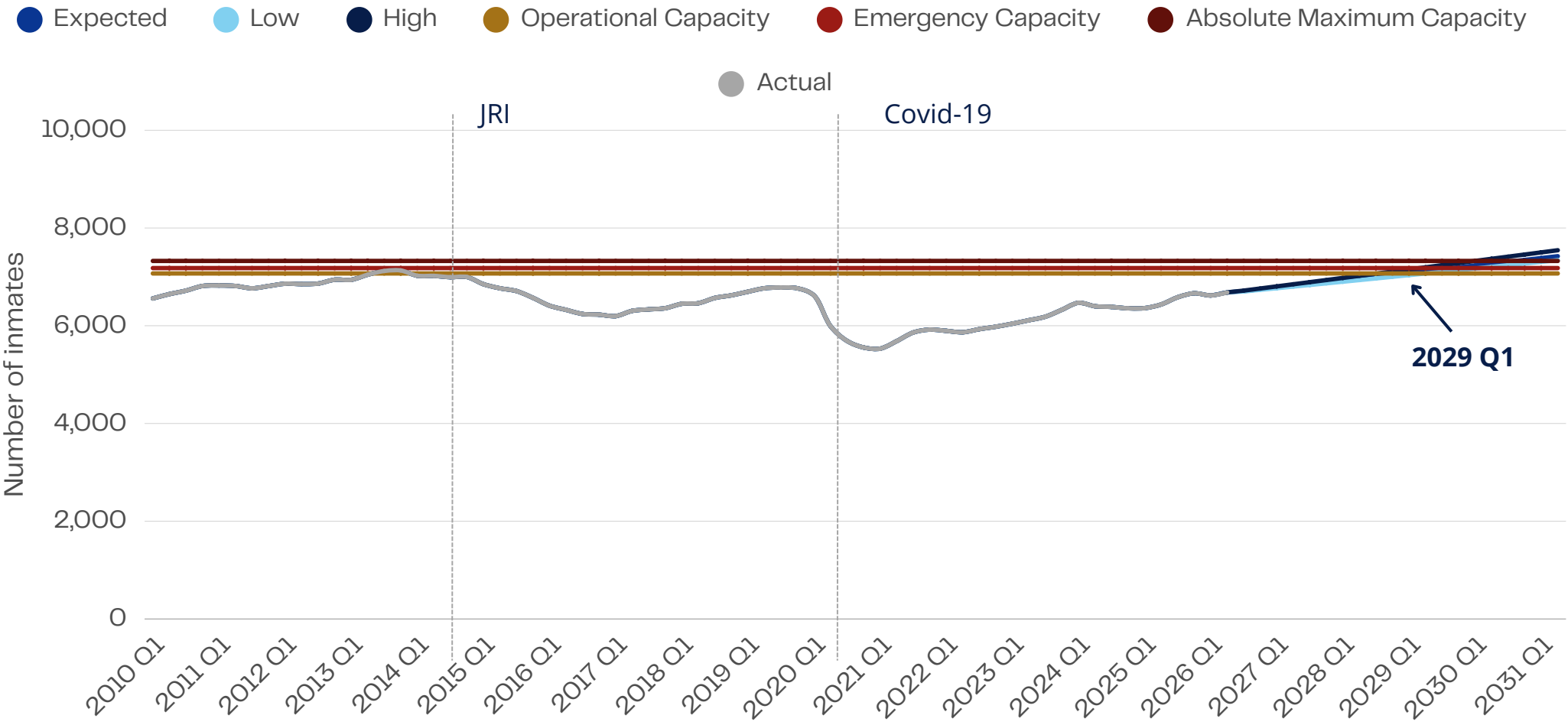
Figure 9 presents three projection scenarios: **Low, Moderate, and High** - based on different weights assigned to two forecasting models. The scenarios represent a range of potential future growth, from more conservative to higher-growth projections.

- **Low Scenario:** Assumes slower future growth and gives more weight to the more conservative model.
- **Moderate/Expected Scenario:** Balances the two models and represents the most likely path for continued growth.
- **High Scenario:** Assumes higher future growth and gives more weight to the model that projects stronger growth.



See the [Appendix](#) for more details about our methodology.

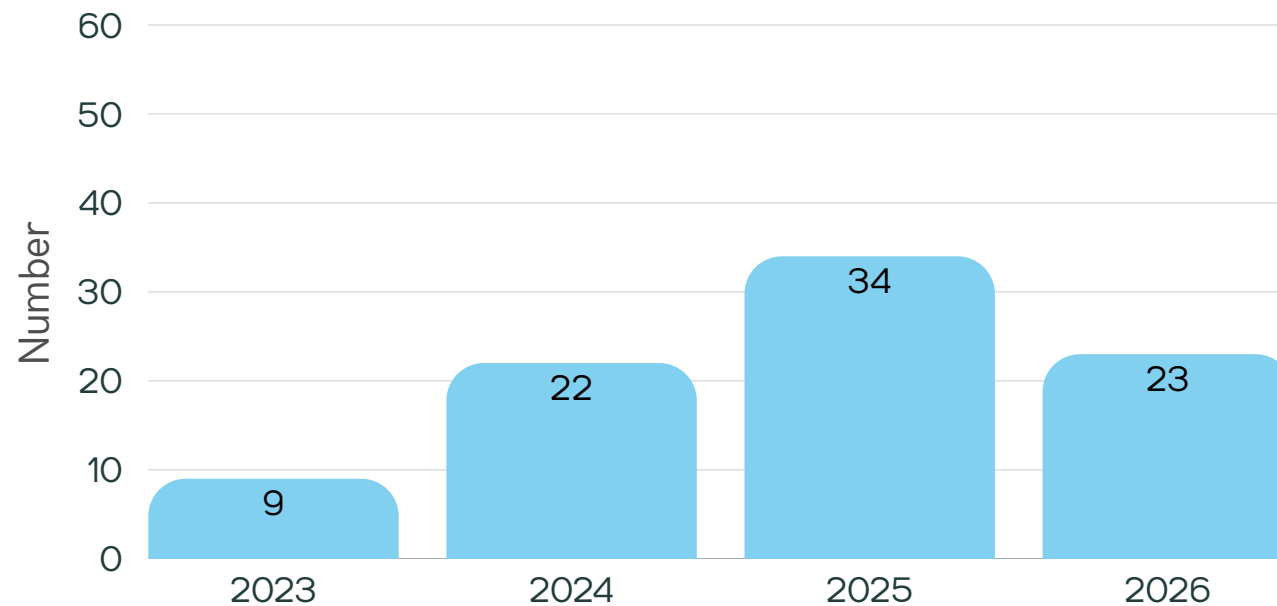
Figure 9: Utah's Prison Population (ADP): Actual vs Projected 2010 Q1 - 2031Q2**



**Note that capacity numbers are noted as of 2026 Q2 and fluctuate through time.

NEW LEGISLATION 2023-2026

Figure 10: New Felony Legislative Changes: 2023-2026

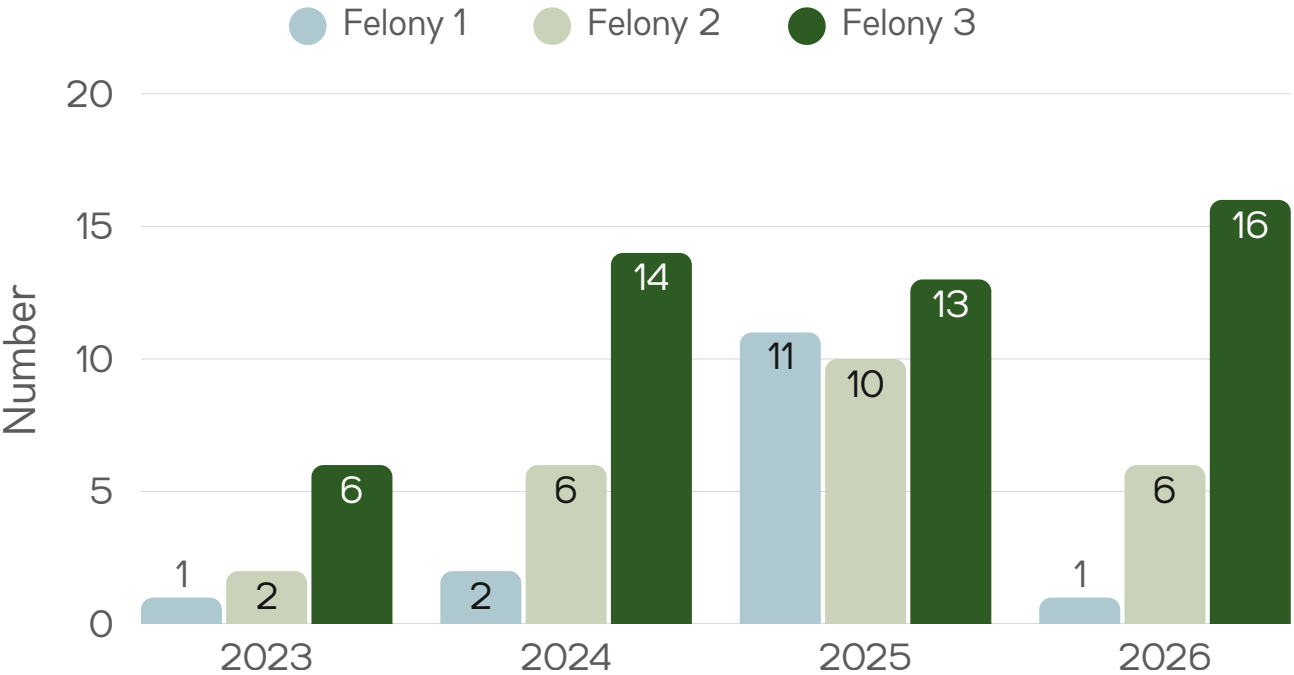


UDC estimated a total annual new inmate bed count of 90, 86, and 8 respectively during 2024-26.

Between 2023 and 2026, **a total of 88 legislative changes** created either *new* felony offenses or *enhanced* or *expanded* existing ones.

New Legislation by Degree: 2023-2026

Figure 11: New Felony Legislative Changes by Degree: 2023-2026



*Data compiled from Utah
Sentencing Commission annual
reports.*

Upcoming UPPP Work

Utah's Prison Population: Today, Historically, and Into the Future

An analysis of key sub-populations expected to drive future prison growth.



UPPP Subpopulation Analysis: Purpose

The UPPP subpopulation analysis is designed to support prison population planning by examining how the composition of the population is changing and what those changes may mean for future growth. The analysis focuses on three areas:

- **Projections:** Projected five-year growth in key UDC subpopulations
- **Drivers:** Drivers of growth within each subpopulation, including changes in admissions, releases, length of stay and location
- **Future Population:** How these changes may shape the future prison population to help inform planning

Our *new* report analyzes 3 areas related to prison population growth:

1

Key Populations

Projects five-year growth in key UDC inmate subpopulations.

2

Prison Drivers

Identifies factors driving growth within each subpopulation.

3

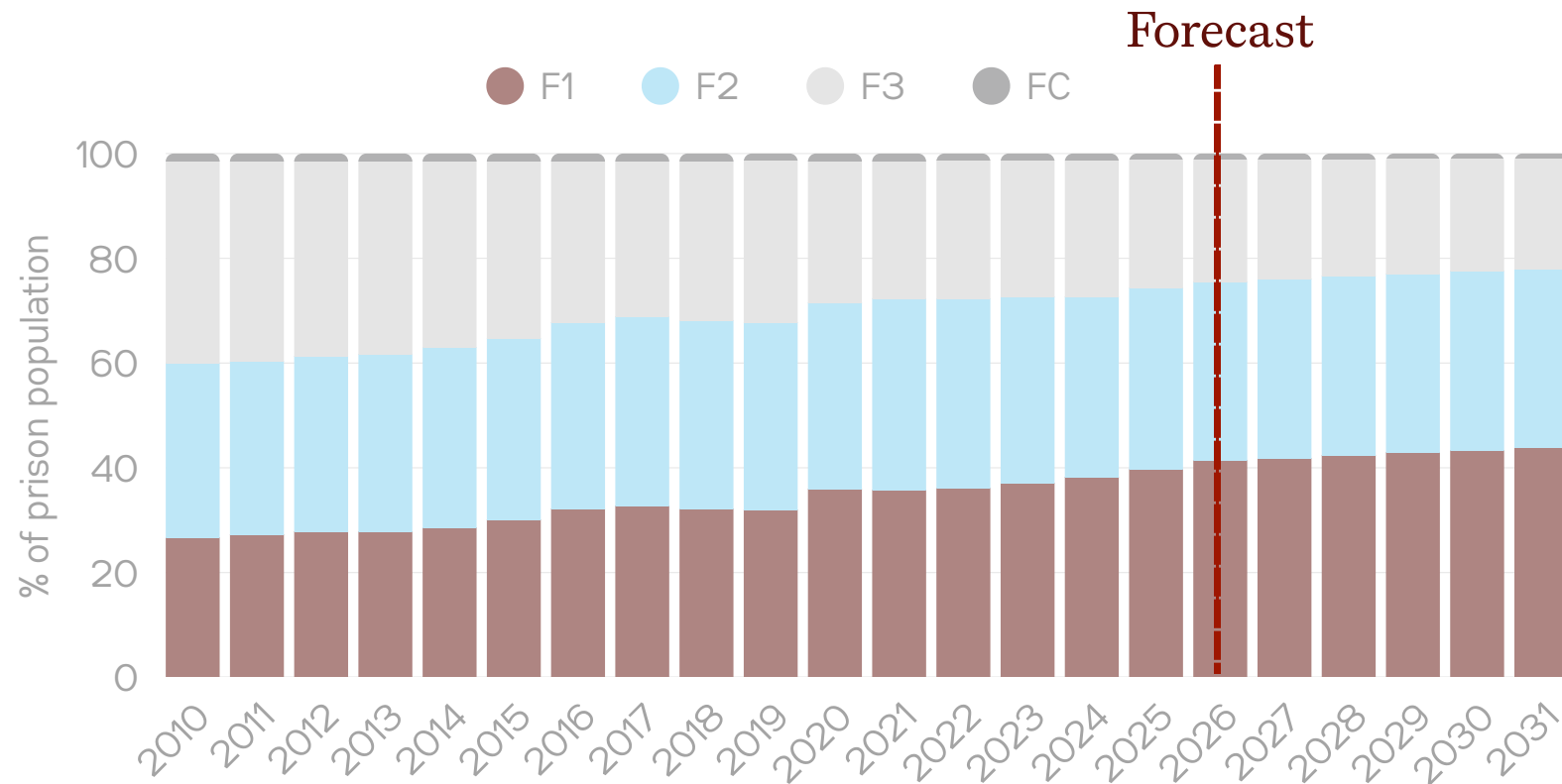
Future Population

Examines how current trends are expected to shape the prison population in 5 years.

Offense Degree Composition Trends

DRAFT

Figure 12: Composition of Utah's Prison Population over Time by Primary Offense Degree: Actual vs Projected: 2010 - 2031

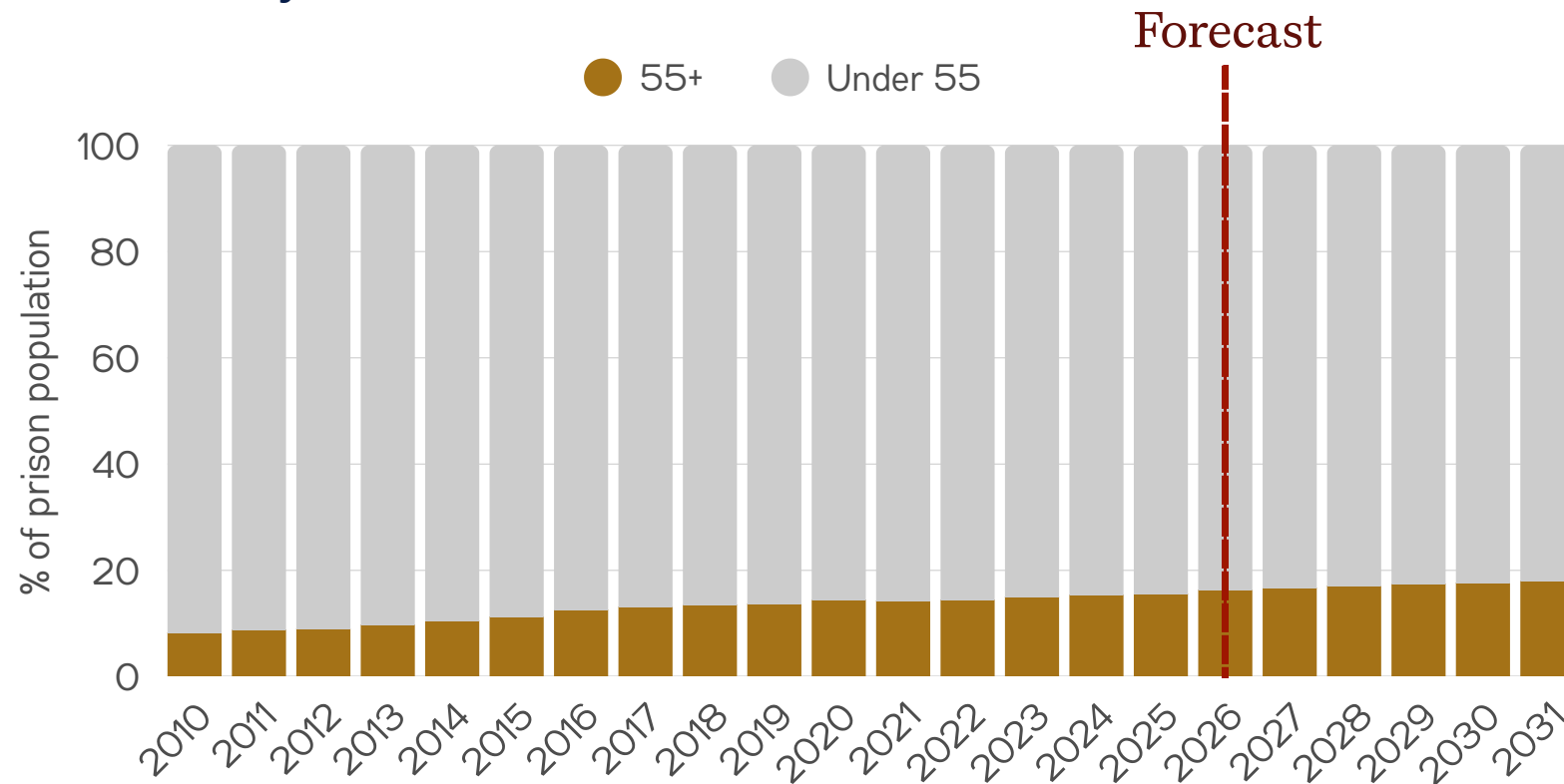


Felony 1's (F1) are predicted to make up ~**45% of the prison population by 2031**, compared to 26% in 2010.

The Share of Aging Inmates is Predicted to Continue to Increase

DRAFT

**Figure 13: Composition of Utah's Prison Population over Time by Age Group:
Actual vs Projected: 2010 - 2031**

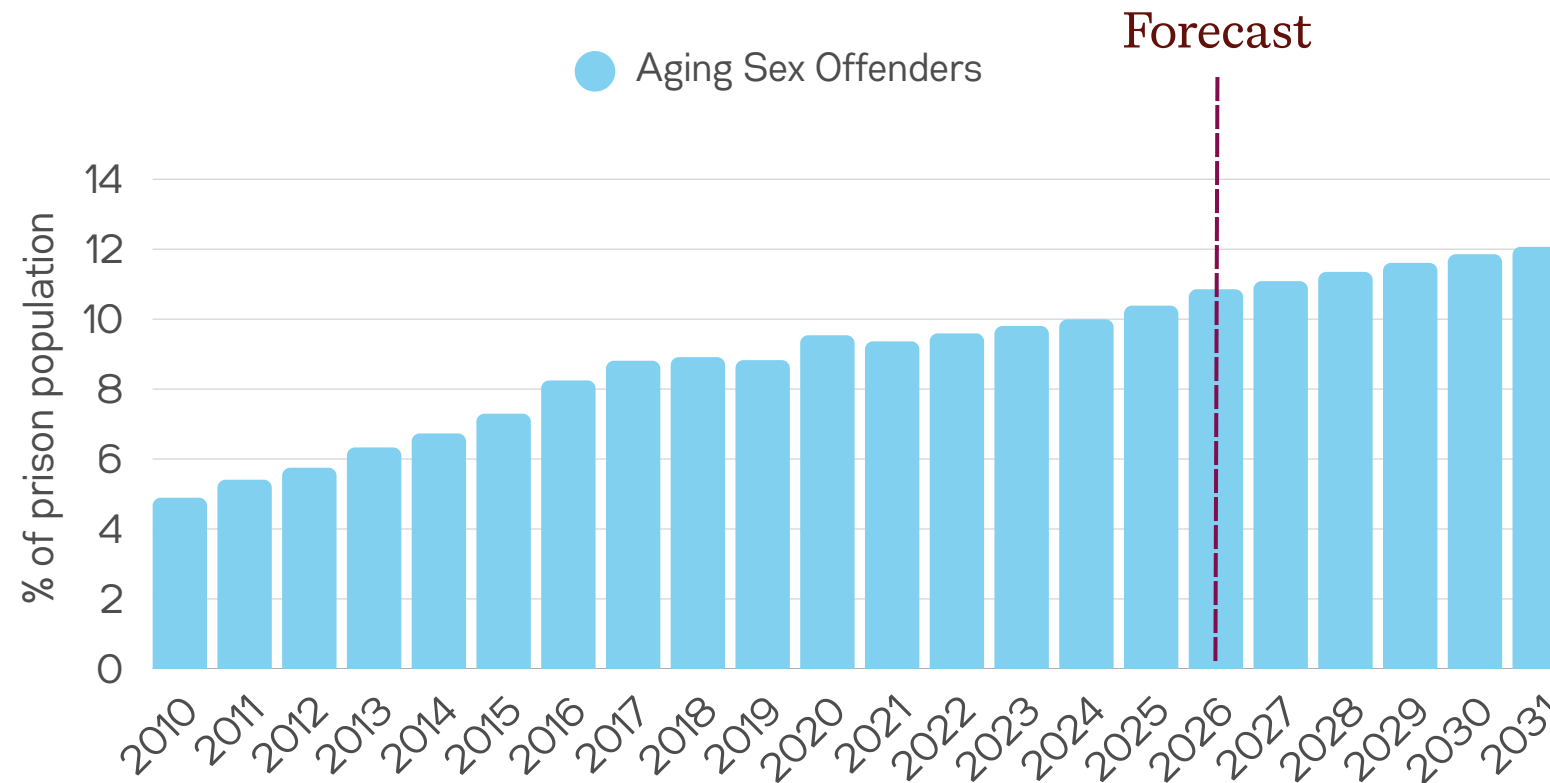


Inmates aged 55 and older **doubled** as a share of the prison population between **2010 and 2026** and is projected to grow further through 2031.

The Aging Sex Offender Population is Projected to Continue to Grow

DRAFT

Figure 14: Percent of Utah's Prison Population that are Aging Sex Offenders: Actual vs Projected: 2010 -2031



Aging sex-offenders (55+) made up ~**5%** of the population in **2010** and are projected to reach **>12%** by **2031**.

Capacity Considerations



Capacity within the correctional system is multifaceted, encompassing actual prison bed availability, county jail space used for overflow and contracting, and housing options in community corrections centers. It is important to consider that operational capacity, the ability to effectively manage inmates, is constrained by staffing levels, program availability, and other operational resources, in addition to physical bed space.

Key-Takeaways: Capacity Considerations



Multifaceted

Capacity includes available prison beds, county jail space used for overflow, and contracted facilities.



Resource Constraints

Capacity can be constrained by insufficient staffing and resource availability even if bed space is available.

Risk Mitigation & Cost Implications



Balancing capacity planning requires managing the risks of overestimation, which can lead to unused resources, and underestimation, which can create operational strain. Regular updates, data analysis, and sensitivity testing can improve projection reliability. Evaluating alternatives to incarceration can also help balance public safety with the costs of expanding prison capacity.

Mitigating risk in projection work and capacity planning requires balancing overestimation, which can lead to unused resources, and underestimation, which may cause operational strain.



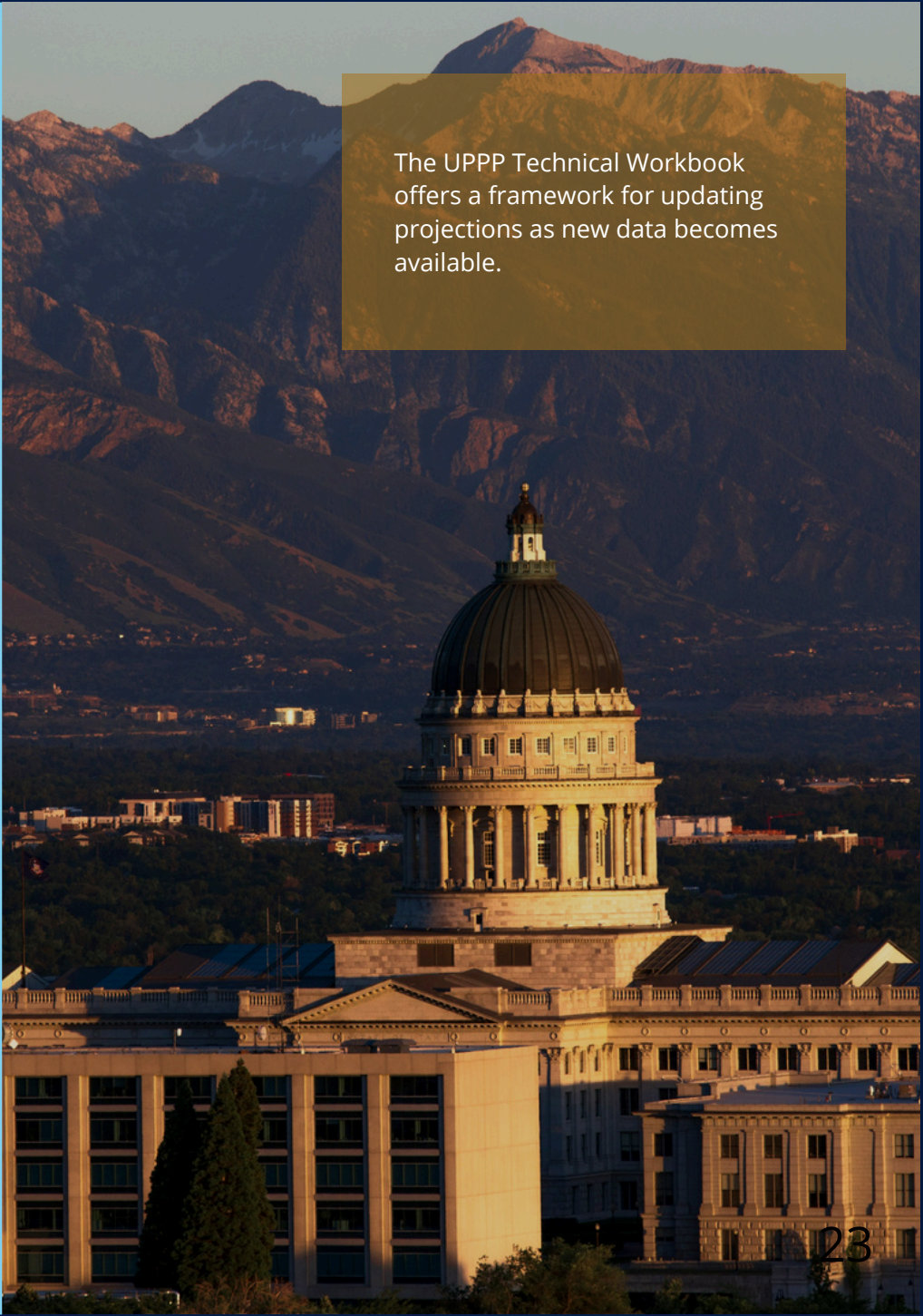
Limitations & Updates



A deeper analysis of recent criminal justice legislation is underway to assess potential implications for future prison population projections. As it has been nearly five years since the onset of COVID-19, post-COVID population trends are becoming a less significant source of uncertainty.

Continuous model validation and refinement are crucial for maintaining projection accuracy and informing effective policy decisions. **The UPPP Technical Workbook provides a framework for updating prison population projections as new data and information becomes available.**

**For details about recent legislative bills passed, please visit this [link](#).*

The background of the slide features a photograph of the Utah State Capitol building, a large neoclassical structure with a prominent dome, set against a backdrop of rugged, snow-capped mountains under a clear sky. A semi-transparent gold-colored rectangular box is overlaid on the upper right portion of the image.

The UPPP Technical Workbook offers a framework for updating projections as new data becomes available.

Conclusion & Recommendations



Reliable prison projections remain an important tool for resource allocation and planning. **Current five-year projections indicate that, absent significant internal, policy, or legislative changes, the population is expected to grow toward capacity over the five-year forecasting period, with annual growth ranging from 1.9% to 2.5%.** Higher-growth scenarios increase the likelihood that this risk will occur sooner.

Given projection uncertainty, evolving legislative impacts, and changing subpopulation trends, we recommend updating the models as new data become available.

Report Takeaways:



Upward Pressure

The prison population is expected to grow at about 2% annually for the next 5 years.



Capacity Measures

Absent significant internal, policy, or legislative changes, it is expected that capacity will be reached in the next 5 years.



Sub-population Work

Detailed forecasting analyses are underway to identify key drivers of prison population growth.



Department of
Criminal Justice

THANK YOU!



We would like to express our gratitude to the Utah Department of Corrections for their collaboration, expertise and for sharing the data underlying this project and report.

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APPENDIX: Data & Methodology

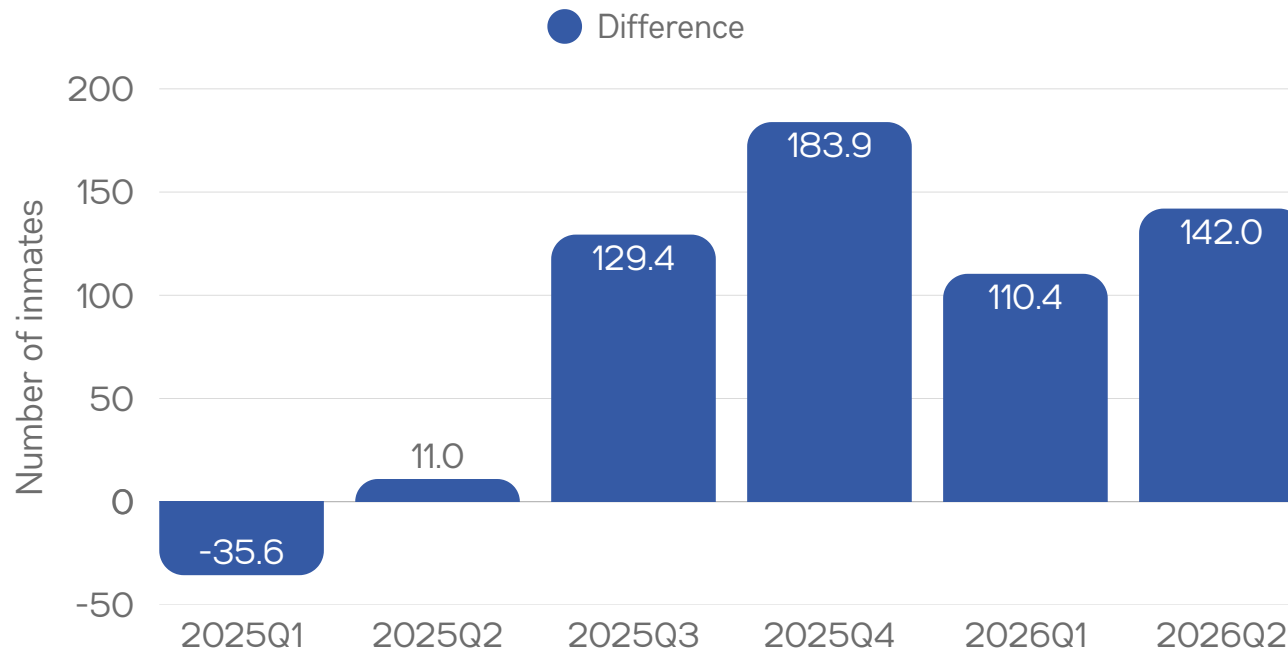


Prison projections were developed using historical quarterly prison data from 2010 Q1 through 2026 Q2 based on UDC's daily average population. Two statistical models were used to generate the projections, incorporating structural breaks to account for major changes, including justice reform and COVID-19. Weighted averages of the two model forecasts were used to develop projection scenarios. Additional factors were reviewed, including Utah's general population growth and trends in violent crime.

2025/26 Error: Actual vs Predicted



Figure A1: Difference in Average Daily Population (ADP) - Actual vs Predicted 2025 Q1 - 2026 Q2



* Numbers are **not** cumulative over time.

The average daily population started to exceed projections in 2025 Q3, informing an **upward adjustment** to the forecasting approach.

Projection Data Table



Year/Quarter	Expected	Low	High
2026 Q3	6708.8	6701.9	6719.1
2026 Q4	6745.9	6735	6762.3
2027 Q1	6783.1	6768.2	6805.4
2027 Q2	6820.3	6801.4	6848.7
2027 Q3	6857.6	6834.6	6891.9
2027 Q4	6894.9	6868	6935.2
2028 Q1	6932.3	6901.4	6978.5
2028 Q2	6969.7	6934.9	7021.9
2028 Q3	7007.2	6968.4	7065.3
2028 Q4	7044.7	7002.1	7108.7
2029 Q1	7082.3	7035.7	7152.2
2029 Q2	7119.9	7069.5	7195.6
2029 Q3	7157.6	7103.3	7239.2
2029 Q4	7195.4	7137.2	7282.7
2030 Q1	7233.2	7171.1	7326.3
2030 Q2	7271.1	7205.2	7369.9
2030 Q3	7309	7239.2	7413.6
2030 Q4	7347	7273.4	7457.3
2031 Q1	7385	7307.6	7501
2031 Q2	7423.1	7341.9	7544.8

- **Operational** = 6,967
- **Emergency** = 7,076
- **Absolute** = 7,326

Projected Numbers
by Scenario

